

Which role are you playing right now?

A self-confrontation guide for the partner who thinks they're not the problem

There's something nobody says plainly to people who have done work on themselves.

Understanding what's happening in a relationship isn't enough to change what happens there. You can name the Karpman drama triangle, recognize ego states, identify psychological games — and find yourself that same evening in the same scene, with the same lines, in the same role. Not from lack of willpower. Not from lack of awareness. Because understanding and seeing are two different things.

Seeing means catching the precise moment when you enter the game. Not after the fact, not in retrospective analysis — in the moment, when it's still possible to do something different.

This guide won't teach you anything you don't already know about relational games. What it proposes is more uncomfortable: identifying the role you play preferentially — the one you slip into without noticing, the one that feels most natural, most justified, sometimes most virtuous. And catching the signal that precedes your entry into that role — before the scene is set, before the lines are assigned.

This isn't an egogram. It's not a clinical diagnosis. It's something simpler and more useful for what we're looking for here: enough recognition to begin seeing differently.

Six scenes. Three possible reactions per scene. A profile that emerges — not to label you, but to give you a foothold from which to work.

One note before you begin: the three reactions proposed for each scene aren't traps. There's no right answer. There's the answer that resembles you most in that moment — not the one you'd like to have, not the one a personal development reader "should" have. The one that arrives first, before you have time to correct it.

That's the one that's useful.

Your dominant role

Scene 1 — The conversation that derails

Your partner is telling you something difficult. You're really listening — you're not looking at your phone, you're asking questions, you're there. At some point they say "forget it" and change the subject. You don't understand what just happened.

Reaction A

"I was really there, I was listening. If they cut off like that, it's because there's something they don't want to look at — not because I did something wrong."

Reaction B

"I should have stayed quiet and just let the silence be. I asked one question too many, or at the wrong moment. I always miss this kind of thing."

Reaction C

"I'm making real efforts and it still ends up like this. At some point I don't know what to do anymore — whatever I try, it's the wrong register."

Scene 2 — The growing gap

Your partner isn't on the same path as you — no therapy, no self-development books, not really interested in "all that." You don't hold it against them. But there are conversations you no longer have with them. And you don't know what to do with the gap that keeps growing.

Reaction A

"I can't hold back who I am so it's more comfortable for them. That's not arrogance — it's just that I can't pretend not to see what I see."

Reaction B

"Maybe I'm the one creating the distance. I talk about all this too much, I expect too much — I exhaust them with levels of conversation they never asked for."

Reaction C

"I try not to show it but it's getting harder. I find myself alone with the questions that matter most to me. This isn't what I imagined."

Scene 3 — The help that isn't received

You can see your partner is struggling. You offer something concrete — an idea, a solution, support. They say "it's fine, I've got it." You sense that no, it's not fine.

Reaction A

"I offered something relevant. If they turn it down, that's their right — but don't come complaining later that nobody helps them."

Reaction B

"Maybe I should have just been there without offering anything. I turn everything into a problem to solve — it's my way of not really being present."

Reaction C

"I don't know how to handle this anymore. If I offer something, it's too much. If I don't, I'm absent. There's no right move."

Scene 4 — The recurring remark

Your partner says something — a criticism, an observation — that you've heard several times before. You've worked on this. You know there's some truth in it. And yet something in you resists, stiffens, or withdraws.

Reaction A

"I hear it. And at the same time — I've genuinely worked on this. Do they see the effort, or are they just trying to be right?"

Reaction B

"They're right. I'm doing it again. I thought I'd made progress but apparently not enough — or not in the right way."

Reaction C

"I say nothing because there's no point defending myself. But internally I'm taking note. It's not the first time and it won't be the last."

Scene 5 — The well-received feedback

Your partner makes a comment about something you did. You take it in — really, you don't defend yourself, you agree, you even thank them. And two hours later you realize you're ruminating. Or justifying yourself internally. Or looking for something comparable they've done.

Reaction A

"I handled it well in the moment — that's already something. What happens in my head afterward is my business. I don't have to expose everything."

Reaction B

"I thought I'd genuinely taken it in. Apparently not. I'm still defending myself — just silently this time."

Reaction C

"I took it in because it was the right thing to do. But what they don't see is everything I've been swallowing for months without ever saying it."

Scene 6 — The moment you go quiet

You have something to say — a request, a frustration, something that matters. You choose not to say it. Not because it's the wrong moment. Because you're anticipating the response, or the cost, or the way it will turn back on you.

Reaction A

"It's not the right time. And I'm not sure it would change anything — I've tried to raise this kind of thing before and it always ends the same way."

Reaction B

"I stay quiet because I can't figure out how to say what I want without it sounding like an attack. Until I have the right words, better to say nothing."

Reaction C

"I keep it to myself. Not out of fear — out of calculation. What I'd lose by saying it outweighs what I'd gain. For now."

What your role is really costing you

The Rescuer

What the role gives you in the short term is real — and that's why it holds.

When you offer, when you listen, when you anticipate what the other person needs before they even ask — you feel useful, present, in your rightful place. There's something deeply satisfying about being the one who sees what the other hasn't seen yet, who holds what the other can't hold alone. This isn't manipulation. It's a way of loving that makes sense — and that probably made sense long before this relationship.

The Rescuer isn't someone trying to dominate. They're someone who learned that their value in a relationship comes through what they bring. That their presence is justified by their usefulness. That if they do nothing, they are nothing — or not enough. This belief is rarely conscious. It operates in the background, silently, like a rule of the game nobody wrote but everyone follows.

What this role costs in the medium term is less visible — because it erodes slowly.

The first thing that erodes is reciprocity. When you're consistently the one who anticipates, offers, and supports — the other person learns not to. Not out of laziness or bad faith. Because you've already occupied that space. There's no longer room for them to be, in turn, the one who sees, who holds, who brings. You've solved the problem before it arose — and in doing so, you've deprived the relationship of a symmetry you both need.

The second thing that erodes is your own visibility. When your role is to be useful, your own needs become secondary — first in the relationship, then in your own awareness. You no longer really know what you want, what you need, what you're missing. You know what the other person should do, what the relationship should be, what's missing for them. You're the one who manages.

And that's where the cost becomes relational in the deepest sense: the other person doesn't really know you. They know your function. Not you.

What do I need in this relationship — and am I asking for it?

The Persecutor

What the role gives you in the short term is less flattering than the Rescuer — and that's why it's harder to recognize.

When you resist, when you take note, when you build an internal case about what's wrong, what was said, what should have been done differently — you feel clear-sighted. Not mean. Clear-sighted. You see things as they are, you don't let yourself be manipulated, you don't yield to

unfair pressure. There's something solid in this position — a kind of integrity, even. You don't say whatever it takes to please. You don't collapse. You hold something.

The cultivated Persecutor — the one who has done work on themselves — doesn't shout. They don't deliberately wound. They observe, retain, formulate internally with a precision the other person will never hear. Their violence is cold and private. And that's exactly why they don't recognize themselves in the word "persecutor" — that word evokes someone else, someone less conscious, someone who hasn't done the work.

But the case file keeps getting thicker.

What this role costs in the medium term is surgical in its precision: it destroys trust without leaving visible traces.

When you accumulate without speaking, the other person lives in a relationship whose real rules they don't know. They sometimes sense something is off — a slight coolness, an inexplicable distance, a reply that's too short. But they have nothing to grasp, nothing to correct, nothing to work with. You said nothing. You reacted well. And yet something has closed.

What it costs the relationship: the other person learns, without you intending it, to stop taking risks with you. To stop opening up completely. To measure what they say, what they show, what they ask for. Not because they're afraid of you in any clinical sense — but because they've learned that certain things create a weather pattern they can't understand or anticipate. They adjust. The relationship shrinks.

What it costs you: you remain alone with what you know. The case you're building serves no purpose — it doesn't change the other person, doesn't change the relationship, doesn't really bring relief. It simply maintains an internal tension you manage alone, in silence, with a surface efficiency that eventually exhausts you.

What am I really risking if I say what I'm noting?

The Victim

What the role gives you in the short term is the least admissible of the three — and therefore the most important to name.

When you step back, when you swallow it, when you choose not to say something because you're anticipating the cost — you're avoiding something specific. Not conflict in general. Not pain in general. You're avoiding the moment when you might ask for something and be refused. You're avoiding the moment when you might show up fully and find that it's not enough. You're avoiding the verdict.

Silence, accommodation, "it's fine, I've got it" — these aren't signs of weakness. They're intelligent strategies, refined over time, to never be in the position of someone who wanted something and

didn't get it. As long as you don't really ask, you can't really be rejected. It's effective protection. It has a cost.

The cultivated Victim — the one who has done work on themselves — doesn't complain. They understand. They contextualize. They see the other person's constraints, their own limits, the complexity of the situation. They're generous in their analysis. And this generosity allows them to never quite articulate what they want — because articulating means exposing yourself.

What this role costs in the medium term touches something deeper than the other two.

It costs the relationship with yourself.

When you organize yourself durably around not asking, not disappointing, not taking up too much space — you become progressively opaque to yourself. You no longer really know what you truly want, because wanting something you won't ask for is a pointless form of suffering. So you stop wanting clearly. You accommodate. You find ways to tell yourself it's fine this way, it's not that serious, you don't really need that.

What it costs the relationship: the other person lives with someone they can't really reach. You're present, functional, often pleasant. But there's a part of you that's never fully there — the part that would want, that's missing something, that's waiting for something without saying so. The other person sometimes senses it, without being able to name it. They might find you distant, elusive, hard to satisfy. Not because you demand too much — because you demand nothing, and that creates a distance neither of you knows how to cross.

What it costs you: a quiet exhaustion. Not the spectacular burnout. A slow wearing down, from managing alone, from understanding on behalf of the other, from finding reasons why it's not that serious. And one day — or gradually, with no specific day — the feeling that the relationship no longer really nourishes you. Without being able to say why, or to whom.

What do I want — and do I believe I have the right to want it?

The turning point

What the previous parts have produced — if they've done their work — is a localized discomfort. Not a general understanding. Something more precise: a recognition of your preferred position in the game, and what it costs you.

Part 3 starts from there. It doesn't propose "getting out of the game" — that phrasing is misleading because it implies there's a stable, definitive position outside the game. That's not the experience of most people doing this work. What exists is a moment — brief, often physical, always personal — where something signals that the game has just begun. And in that moment, it's still possible to do something different.

That's the moment we're looking for here. Not the theoretical signal. Yours.

Finding your signal

The entry signal into the game isn't a thought. It precedes thought. That's why we miss it — because by the time we start analyzing what's happening, we're already inside.

It might be physical: a slight tension in the chest, shoulders rising, jaw tightening, a shift in breathing. It might be emotional: a subtle surge of urgency, a sudden need to clarify or correct, an inner closing that feels like tiredness. It might be situational: a particular tone in the other person's voice, a phrasing you've heard before, a silence of a certain quality.

This signal is stable. It repeats from scene to scene, week to week, sometimes from one relationship to another. You've already experienced it — probably tonight, probably yesterday. The question isn't to create it but to recognize it.

Go back to the scene where you recognized yourself most clearly in Part 1. Read it slowly. Before the reaction you chose arrives — what's happening in your body? Not during the reaction. Just before. In the fraction of a second when something shifts.

That's it.

One intervention — not five

What follows isn't a protocol. It's a single intervention, adapted to your dominant role. It's not designed to resolve the scene. It's designed to create a one-second gap between the signal and the automatic reaction. One second is enough to change what happens next.

If your dominant role is the Rescuer:

At the moment you feel the impulse to offer, explain, anticipate — ask yourself one question before acting: *is someone asking me for something?* Not "could I help" — is someone actually asking you for something. If the answer is no, stay there without doing anything. Just present,

without a function.

If your dominant role is the Persecutor:

At the moment you sense you're starting to note, retain, formulate internally — name it out loud, to yourself first if needed: *I'm building a case file*. Not to blame yourself. To step out of automatic mode. Then one question: *can I say one thing from this case file right now, to the other person, simply?*

If your dominant role is the Victim:

At the moment you sense you're choosing not to speak, to accommodate, to manage alone — before closing off, put into words for yourself what you won't say: *what I want right now is...* Not with any obligation to say it. To not lose contact with what you want. Saying it to the other person comes second. Knowing what you want is the first step.

These interventions don't work cold, read once in a guide. They require practice in the moment — which means missing them the first times, applying them after the fact, noticing you did the same thing again. That's normal. It's not a failure of method. It's the difference between understanding and seeing — the one the introduction was pointing at.

This guide has given you a foothold. What we do with that foothold is a different conversation.

Something has probably happened.

If you've arrived here with a degree of honesty — without choosing the reaction you'd have liked to have, without placing yourself in the most flattering role, without turning the exercise into an analysis of your partner — something has probably happened.

Not a revelation. Something more subtle and more useful: a slight shift in how you see yourself in the relationship. A recognition you hadn't yet put into words. A discomfort localized where there was previously a vague zone.

That discomfort is a good sign. It means you're touching something real — not a concept, not a mechanism observed in the other person, but your own position in what keeps replaying.

This guide has a clear limit, and it's important to name it.

It can produce recognition. It cannot produce lasting change. Recognition is necessary — without it, nothing begins. But it's not sufficient. What follows recognition requires something else: repetition, confrontation, often an outside perspective that sees what you can't see alone. Not because you lack the capacity — but because the role you play preferentially is precisely the one that feels most natural, most justified, most invisible to yourself.

That's the nature of the game. You can't get out alone of what you can't see alone.

If something in this guide has created an opening — a question about your role, about what it costs you, about the signal that precedes your entry into the scene — and you want to go further than a guide can take you, this is the moment for a conversation.

Not a program. Not a twelve-step method. A conversation with someone who can hold the same level of complexity as you, without simplifying, without prescribing — and who can see, from the outside, what you can't see from the inside.

That's what I offer.

— Pascal | Integral Pathways

Book a conversation: calendly.com/pascalogil

integralpathways.substack.com